PREFACE

For the last decade, I have had not just a ringside view of foreign policymaking, but the privilege to participate in the process as well. As External Affairs Minister (EAM) and previously as Foreign Secretary and Ambassador to the US, the analysis, debates and strategizing of this period are exercises in which I have been deeply involved. It is not my intention to pen my memoirs, certainly not while still in the midst of discharging responsibilities. But because this has been a deeply transformational era, it is also imperative that an objective explanation of the changes is provided to the public. The analytical world appears to be tangled in its own pre-conceptions and struggling to grasp developments that do not fit its mould. The political arena has become exceptionally polemical, with some parties articulating positions that go against their own grain. The burden of communicating, in that sense, falls on the actual participants. With an earlier experience of presenting my thoughts, there was a natural inclination to take up this challenge. This is the thought process behind this book.

My own background as a diplomat well into a fifth decade biases me in favour of presenting a clinical picture of the global landscape, its challenges and complications as well as of the implications for India and a suggested course of action. This is what I have done for a living all these years. It is not that we avoid personalities and relationships or underplay their importance. On the contrary, so much of diplomacy is about chemistry and credibility that the human factor is always central to an accurate judgement. But what usually happens is that a vast number of objective and subjective elements are distilled into an integrated picture, which acquires a relatively dispassionate character.

In this particular endeavour, I contemplated a world that is struggling with economic disruptions, the Covid pandemic, the Ukraine conflict, an exploding West Asia (Middle East) and sharpening great power competition, and sought to assess India’s prospects in ascending the global hierarchy in such volatile conditions. That exercise brought home to me how much we have progressed in the preceding years and how differently we are now seen as compared to the era before 2014. India has today moved out of the defensive non-aligned posture, engaging multiple nations on a